

Western Civilization, Philosophy, and Literature — 1-Year Curriculum

Week	Theme	Core Readings (Primary + Secondary + Durant)
1	Origins of Civilization & Cosmic Order	Durant, <i>Our Oriental Heritage</i> (“Sumeria,” “Egypt,” “Babylonia,” “The Hebrews”); <i>Code of Hammurabi</i> ; <i>Epic of Gilgamesh</i> ; <i>Genesis</i> 1–3; Hesiod, <i>Theogony</i> ; Heraclitus, <i>Fragments</i> ; Burckhardt, <i>The Greeks and Greek Civilization</i> ; Lloyd, <i>Early Greek Science</i> .
2	Early Greece: Epic & Civic Beginnings	Durant, <i>Life of Greece</i> (“Heroic Age”); Homer, <i>Iliad</i> I, VI, XXII, XXIV; <i>Odyssey</i> IX, XI; Hesiod, <i>Works and Days</i> ; Solon & Tyrtaeus; Presocratics (Thales–Parmenides); Burnet, <i>Early Greek Philosophy</i> .
3	Tragedy, War & the Polis	Durant, <i>Life of Greece</i> (“Golden Age”); Aeschylus, <i>Oresteia</i> ; Herodotus, <i>Histories</i> I, VII; Thucydides II.35–54; Sophocles, <i>Antigone</i> ; Jaeger, <i>Paideia</i> I; Kitto, <i>The Greeks</i> .
4	Philosophy & the Examined Life	Durant, <i>Life of Greece</i> (“Periclean Athens,” “Plato and Aristotle”); Plato, <i>Apology</i> ; <i>Republic</i> I–II, VII; Aristophanes, <i>Clouds</i> ; Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> I; <i>Poetics</i> ; Finley, <i>Four Stages of Greek Thought</i> .
5	Aristotle & Greek Science	Durant, <i>Life of Greece</i> (“Aristotle and Greek Science”); Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> I; <i>Physics</i> II; <i>De Anima</i> II; <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> I; Polybius VI; Lloyd, <i>Polarity and Analogy</i> ; van der Waerden, <i>Science Awakening</i> .
6	Civic Virtue & Exemplarity	Durant, <i>Life of Greece</i> (“Decline of Greece”); Plutarch, <i>Lives</i> (“Lycurgus,” “Solon,” “Pericles,” “Alexander,” “Caesar,” “Brutus”); Cicero, <i>On Duties</i> I; Fustel de Coulanges, <i>The Ancient City</i> .
7	Hellenistic Philosophy & Empire	Durant, <i>Caesar and Christ</i> (“Rome Before Caesar”); Arrian, <i>Anabasis</i> ; Epicurus, <i>Letter to Menoeceus</i> ; Epictetus, <i>Enchiridion</i> ; Seneca, <i>Letters</i> ; Marcus Aurelius, <i>Meditations</i> II, IV, VII, XII ; Lucretius, <i>On the Nature of Things</i> II; Beard, <i>SPQR</i> ; Gibbon, <i>Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire</i> Vol I Chs I–III (Extent & Military Constitution of the Empire).
8	Rome, Law & Christianity	Durant, <i>Caesar and Christ</i> (“Empire,” “Triumph of Christianity”); Livy I; Tacitus XV; Virgil, <i>Aeneid</i> I, VI; Augustine, <i>Confessions</i> VII–IX; Brown, <i>World of Late Antiquity</i> ; Gibbon, <i>Decline and Fall</i> Vol II Chs XV–XX (Progress of the Christian Religion).
9	Early Middle Ages	Durant, <i>Age of Faith</i> (“Byzantine Civilization,” “Rise of Islam”); <i>Rule of St. Benedict</i> ; Boethius, <i>Consolation</i> ; Einhard, <i>Life of Charlemagne</i> ; Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> ; Southern, <i>Making of the Middle Ages</i> ; Gibbon, <i>Decline and Fall</i> Vol IV Chs XXXIX–XLVII (Fall of the Western Empire).
10	Scholasticism & Mysticism	Durant, <i>Age of Faith</i> (“Medieval Church,” “Scholastics,” “Mystics”); Aquinas, <i>Summa Theologiae</i> Ia Q1–2, Ia IIae Q90–94; Bonaventure, <i>Journey</i> ; Dante, <i>Inferno</i> I–V, XXXIII; Julian of Norwich, <i>Revelations</i> ; Gilson, <i>Spirit of Medieval Philosophy</i> ; Gibbon, <i>Decline and Fall</i> Vol V Chs XLVIII–LI (Reign of Justinian; Empire in the East).
11	Renaissance Humanism	Durant, <i>The Renaissance</i> (“Florence and the Medici,” “Machiavelli and Humanism”); Petrarch, <i>Letters</i> ; Pico, <i>Oration</i> ; Machiavelli, <i>Prince</i> ; Castiglione, <i>Courtier</i> ; Shakespeare, <i>Hamlet</i> ; Burckhardt,

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		<i>Civilization of the Renaissance in Italy.</i>
12	Reformation & Skepticism	Durant, <i>The Reformation</i> (“Luther,” “Calvin and Geneva”); Luther, <i>95 Theses</i> ; Calvin, <i>Institutes</i> I.1–3; Erasmus, <i>Praise of Folly</i> ; Montaigne, <i>Essays</i> ; Duffy, <i>Stripping of the Altars</i> ; Skinner, <i>Foundations of Modern Political Thought</i> .
13	Science & Method	Durant, <i>Age of Reason Begins</i> (“Galileo and the New Science”); Bacon, <i>Novum Organum</i> ; Galileo, <i>Letter to Christina</i> ; Descartes, <i>Discourse on Method</i> ; Pascal, <i>Pensées</i> ; Koyré, <i>From the Closed World to the Infinite Universe</i> .
14	Political Order & Nature	Durant, <i>Age of Reason Begins</i> (“Hobbes and Spinoza”); Hobbes, <i>Leviathan</i> XIII–XVIII; Spinoza, <i>Ethics</i> I–II; Milton, <i>Paradise Lost</i> I, IX; Cassirer, <i>Philosophy of the Enlightenment</i> .
15	Faith & Reason	Durant, <i>Age of Louis XIV</i> (“Philosophers of Faith”); Descartes, <i>Meditations</i> III–V; Leibniz, <i>Monadology</i> ; Pascal, <i>Pensées</i> ; Racine, <i>Phèdre</i> ; Outram, <i>The Enlightenment</i> .
16	Natural Law & Enlightenment	Durant, <i>Age of Voltaire</i> (“Philosophical Climate”); Locke, <i>Second Treatise</i> ; Newton, <i>Principia</i> Defs & Laws; Vico, <i>New Science</i> Intro; Pope, <i>Essay on Man</i> ; Gay, <i>The Enlightenment</i> .
17	Enlightenment & Critique	Durant, <i>Age of Voltaire</i> (“Hume and Rousseau”); Hume, <i>Enquiry</i> §§2–5; Rousseau, <i>Social Contract</i> I; Kant, Groundwork Preface & § I; Critique of Pure Reason (B-Preface, Introduction, Transcendental Aesthetic) ; Voltaire, <i>Candide</i> ; Cassirer, <i>Kant’s Life and Thought</i> .
18	Revolution & Rights	Durant, <i>Rousseau and Revolution</i> (“French Revolution”); <i>Declaration of Independence</i> ; <i>Rights of Man</i> ; Smith, <i>Wealth of Nations</i> I; Goethe, <i>Faust</i> I; Barzun, <i>From Dawn to Decadence</i> .
19	Romanticism & the Self	Durant, <i>Age of Napoleon</i> (“Romantic Rebellion”); Hegel, <i>Phenomenology of Spirit</i> Preface & “Self-Consciousness”; Wordsworth & Coleridge, <i>Lyrical Ballads</i> ; Blake, <i>Marriage of Heaven and Hell</i> ; Berlin, <i>Roots of Romanticism</i> .
20	Industrialism & Ethics	Durant, <i>Age of Napoleon</i> (“Industrial Society”); Hegel, <i>Philosophy of Right</i> Preface §§1–33, 142–157; Engels, <i>Condition of the Working Class</i> ; Marx, <i>Economic Manuscripts</i> ; Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i> ; Thompson, <i>Making of the English Working Class</i> .
21	Faith, Science & Doubt	Durant, <i>Age of Reason Revisited</i> ; Darwin, <i>Origin of Species</i> 3–4; Kierkegaard, <i>Fear and Trembling</i> Problema I; Comte, <i>Positive Philosophy</i> I; Tennyson, <i>In Memoriam</i> ; Holmes, <i>Age of Wonder</i> .
22	Modern Self & Liberty	Durant, <i>Age of Napoleon</i> (“Liberal Europe”); Mill, <i>On Liberty</i> ; Nietzsche, <i>Genealogy of Morals</i> I–II; Ibsen, <i>A Doll’s House</i> ; Williams, <i>Culture and Society</i> .
23	Pessimism & Realism	Durant, <i>Age of Napoleon</i> (“Arts in Transition”); Schopenhauer, <i>World as Will and Representation</i> II §§18–22; <i>On the Suffering of the World</i> ; Feuerbach, <i>Essence of Christianity</i> Intro; Flaubert, <i>Madame Bovary</i> ; Tolstoy, <i>Anna Karenina</i> ; Magee, <i>Philosophy of Schopenhauer</i> .
24–26	Democracy, Pragmatism & Modernism	Durant, <i>Age of Napoleon</i> (“Democratic Experiment,” “Scientific Spirit,” “Modern Mind”); Tocqueville, <i>Democracy in America</i> I; Marx, <i>Communist Manifesto</i> ; Whitman, <i>Leaves of Grass</i> ; William James, <i>Pragmatism</i> ; Dewey, <i>Experience and Nature</i> ; Freud,

Week	Theme	Core Readings (Primary + Secondary + Durant)
		<i>Interpretation of Dreams</i> II; Bergson, <i>Creative Evolution</i> Intro; Conrad, <i>Heart of Darkness</i> ; Auerbach, <i>Mimesis</i> ; Freud <i>Introductory Lectures on Psycho-Analysis</i> (Lect. I–III, V); Freud <i>Civilization and Its Discontents</i> (chs. I–II, V–VIII).
27	The Great War & Disillusionment	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“War and Civilization”); Husserl, <i>Ideas I</i> §§27–49; Russell, <i>Problems of Philosophy</i> ; Owen, Poems; Remarque, <i>All Quiet on the Western Front</i> ; Kuhn, <i>Structure of Scientific Revolutions</i> .
28	Totalitarianism & Alienation	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Power and Morality”); Heidegger, <i>Being and Time</i> §§1–6; Arendt, <i>Origins of Totalitarianism</i> III; Kafka, <i>Metamorphosis</i> ; Löwith, <i>Meaning in History</i> .
29	Existentialism & the Absurd	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Man and History”); Sartre, <i>Existentialism Is a Humanism</i> ; Beauvoir, <i>Ethics of Ambiguity</i> ; Camus, <i>The Plague</i> ; Orwell, 1984; Marcel, <i>Homo Viator</i> .
30	Renewal & Meaning	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Is Progress Real?”); Gadamer, <i>Truth and Method</i> Intro; Beckett, <i>Waiting for Godot</i> ; Arendt, <i>Between Past and Future</i> .
31	Civilizational Decline	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Civilizations and Cultures”); Spengler, <i>Decline of the West I</i> Intro; Adorno & Horkheimer, <i>Dialectic of Enlightenment</i> ; Borges, <i>Ficciones</i> ; Steiner, <i>Heidegger</i> .
32	Decolonization & Global South	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“History and the Earth”); Fanon, <i>Wretched of the Earth</i> ; Gandhi, <i>Hind Swaraj</i> ; Achebe, <i>Things Fall Apart</i> .
33	1960s Revolt & Freedom	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Freedom and Order”); Marcuse, <i>One-Dimensional Man</i> ; García Márquez, <i>One Hundred Years of Solitude</i> .
34	Feminism & Identity	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Character and History”); Beauvoir, <i>Second Sex</i> ; Butler, <i>Gender Trouble</i> ; Morrison, <i>Beloved</i> .
35	Structuralism & Myth	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“History and Ideas”); Saussure, <i>Course in General Linguistics</i> Pt I; Lévi-Strauss, <i>The Savage Mind</i> 1–2; Calvino, <i>If on a Winter’s Night a Traveler</i> .
36	Post-Structuralism & Difference	Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Progress and Decay”); Derrida, <i>Of Grammatology</i> Preface & Ch 2; **Deleuze, <i>Difference and Repetition</i> Chs
1–2, Conclusion; Deleuze & Guattari, <i>A Thousand Plateaus</i> “Rhizome,” Plateaus 1 & 3**; Lyotard, <i>Postmodern Condition</i> ; Baudrillard, <i>Simulacra and Simulation</i> ; Pynchon, <i>Crying of Lot 49</i> ; Colebrook, <i>Understanding Deleuze</i> .		
37 Ethics & Community Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Morals and History”); MacIntyre, <i>After Virtue</i> 1–3; Rorty, <i>Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature</i> Pt I; Beckett, <i>Krapp’s Last Tape</i> .		
38 Neoliberalism & Media Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Economics and War”); Lyotard, <i>Postmodern Condition</i> ; Baudrillard, <i>Simulacra and Simulation</i> ; Rushdie, <i>Midnight’s Children</i> .		
39 Posthumanism & Biopolitics Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Man and His Destiny”); Spengler, <i>Man and Technics</i> ; Haraway, “Cyborg Manifesto”; Agamben, <i>Homo Sacer</i> ; Dick, <i>Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?</i> .		
40 Ecology & the Anthropocene Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“History and the Earth”); Jonas, <i>Imperative of Responsibility</i> ; Latour, <i>We Have Never Been Modern</i> ; Ghosh, <i>Great Derangement</i> ; Morton, <i>Hyperobjects</i> .		
41 Globalization & Pluralism Durant, <i>Lessons of History</i> (“Civilizations and Cultures”); Appiah,		

Cosmopolitanism; Coetzee, *Elizabeth Costello*; Bauman, *Liquid Modernity*. |
42	Memory & Trauma	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Lessons of History”); Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*; Sebald, *Austerlitz*.
43	Digital Culture & Knowledge	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“History and Progress”); Floridi, *Ethics of Information*; Wallace, *Infinite Jest*.
44	Populism & Crisis of Democracy	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Freedom and Order”); Sloterdijk, *Rage and Time*; Žižek, *Violence*; Atwood, *Handmaid’s Tale*.
45	Global Modernities	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Character and History”); Mbembe, *Critique of Black Reason*; Adichie, *Half of a Yellow Sun*.
46	Economics & Inequality	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Economics and War”); Marx, *Capital* I sel.; Piketty, *Capital in the 21st Century* Intro; Rawls, *Theory of Justice* §§1–4.
47	Science & Consciousness	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Science and Progress”); Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind* Ch 3; Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?”; McEwan, *Machines Like Me*.
48	Technology & Surveillance	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Man and His Destiny”); Foucault, *Birth of Biopolitics* 1–3; Zuboff, *Surveillance Capitalism*; Gibson, *Neuromancer*.
49	Religion & Secularism	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“History and Religion”); *Vatican II* sel.; Taylor, *A Secular Age* Intro; Eliot, *Four Quartets*.
50	Ecology & Hope	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“History and the Earth”); Morton, *Hyperobjects*; Latour, *Facing Gaia*; Robinson, *Ministry for the Future*.
51	Migration & Identity	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Civilizations and Cultures”); Appadurai, *Modernity at Large* 1–3; Bhabha, *Location of Culture* 1; Hamid, *Exit West*.
52	Future of the Human	Durant, *Lessons of History* (“Man and His Destiny”); *Transhumanist Manifesto*; Bostrom, *Superintelligence* Ch 1; Harari, *Homo Deus* Chs 1–3; Le Guin, *Dispossessed*.

Great call. I did a careful pass over every era and patched the biggest gaps so the bibliography truly matches a broad Great-Books/Western Civ standard while staying faithful to your table. I’ve **added missing core items** (marked [NEW]) and kept everything else intact. Where I added beyond your table, I labeled them **Optional [NEW]** so you can include or omit without breaking the flow.

Bibliography



I. Ancient Near East & Archaic Greece (Weeks 1–2)

Primary

- *Code of Hammurabi* — §§1–25, 100–130.
- *Epic of Gilgamesh* — Tablets I–III, XI (trans. Andrew George).
- *Genesis* 1–3 (NRSV or LXX).
- Hesiod, *Theogony* 1–232; *Works and Days* 1–285 (trans. M. L. West).
- **Presocratics (core selections)** — Thales, Anaximander, Heraclitus (DK B1–B130), Parmenides (frs. 1–8), Democritus (KRS frs.).

- Kirk, Raven & Schofield, *The Presocratic Philosophers* (2e) — **Read** Intro + chs. on the above. [NEW]
- (Alt. reference) Diels–Kranz, *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*. [NEW]
- Homer, *Iliad* I, VI, XXII, XXIV; *Odyssey* IX, XI (trans. Fagles).
- Solon & Tyrtaeus — Elegiac fragments (Loeb).

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Our Oriental Heritage; The Life of Greece* (Bk I–II).
- W. K. C. Guthrie, *History of Greek Philosophy*, Vol. I. [NEW]
- John Burnet, *Early Greek Philosophy*.
- G. E. R. Lloyd, *Early Greek Science*.
- Jacob Burckhardt, *The Greeks and Greek Civilization*.
- Jonathan Barnes, *The Presocratic Philosophers*. [NEW]



II. Classical Greece (Weeks 3–6)

Primary

- Aeschylus, *Oresteia* (all 3 plays).
- Sophocles, *Antigone*.
- Herodotus, *Histories* I.1–95; VII.5–40.
- Thucydides, *History* II.35–54 (Funeral Oration & Plague).
- Plato, *Apology*; *Republic* I–II, VII (514a–521b).
- Aristophanes, *Clouds*.
- Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* I.1–13; *Poetics* 1–16; *Physics* II.1–3; *Metaphysics* I.1–2.
- Polybius, *Histories* VI.1–18.
- Plutarch, *Lives* (“Lycurgus,” “Solon,” “Pericles,” “Alexander,” “Caesar,” “Brutus”).
- Cicero, *On Duties* I.1–35.

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *The Life of Greece* (Bk III–V).
- Werner Jaeger, *Paideia* Vol. I.
- H. D. F. Kitto, *The Greeks*.
- John Finley, *Four Stages of Greek Thought*.
- A. A. Long, *Greek Models of Mind and Self*.
- Fustel de Coulanges, *The Ancient City*.



III. Hellenistic & Roman World (Weeks 7–10)

Primary

- Epicurus, *Letter to Menoeceus*; *Principal Doctrines* (1–40).
- Seneca, *Letters* 1–18, 47, 77.
- Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1–10, 35–50.
- Lucretius, *On the Nature of Things* II.1–332.
- Livy, *Early History of Rome* I (Romulus–Numa).
- Tacitus, *Annals* XV (Great Fire).
- Virgil, *Aeneid* I, VI.
- **Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* II, IV, VII, XII. [NEW]**
- Augustine, *Confessions* VII–IX.
- **(Optional) Augustine, *City of God* XIX (“The Supreme Good”). [NEW]**

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Caesar and Christ; The Age of Faith* (transitions).
- **Gibbon, *Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire* — Womersley ed.**
 - Vol. I chs. I–III (Extent & Military Constitution).
 - Vol. II chs. XV–XX (Progress of the Christian Religion).
 - Vol. IV chs. XXXIX–XLVII (Fall of the Western Empire).
 - Vol. V chs. XLVIII–LI (Justinian; the East).
- Mary Beard, *SPQR*.
- Peter Brown, *The World of Late Antiquity*.
- R. W. Southern, *The Making of the Middle Ages*.



IV. Medieval Christendom (Weeks 9–10)

Primary

- *Rule of St. Benedict* — chs. 1–7, 39–48.
- Boethius, *Consolation of Philosophy* I–V.
- Einhard, *Life of Charlemagne*.
- Anselm, *Proslogion* I–III.
- Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia Q1–2; Ia IIae Q90–94.

- Bonaventure, *Journey of the Mind to God*.
- Dante, *Inferno* I–V, XXXIII.
- Julian of Norwich, *Revelations* (Long Text, 2–27).
- **(Optional) Avicenna, *Metaphysics* (Selections). [NEW]**
- **(Optional) Averroes, *Long Commentary on De Anima* (Selections). [NEW]**

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *The Age of Faith*.
- Etienne Gilson, *The Spirit of Medieval Philosophy*.
- C. S. Lewis, *The Discarded Image*.
- Edward Grant, *Foundations of Modern Science in the Middle Ages*. [NEW]
- A. C. Crombie, *Augustine to Galileo*.



V. Renaissance & Reformation (Weeks 11–12)

Primary

- Petrarch, *Letters* (I.1; III.1; XXIII.19).
- Pico, *Oration on the Dignity of Man*.
- Machiavelli, *The Prince* 1–10, 15–18.
- Castiglione, *The Courtier* I.
- Erasmus, *Praise of Folly*.
- Luther, *95 Theses; Freedom of a Christian*.
- Calvin, *Institutes* I.1–3.
- Montaigne, “Of Experience.”
- Shakespeare, *Hamlet*.
- **(Optional) Thomas More, *Utopia* Book I. [NEW]**

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *The Renaissance; The Reformation*.
 - Burckhardt, *Civilization of the Renaissance in Italy*.
 - Kristeller, *Renaissance Thought and Its Sources*.
 - Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition*.
 - Skinner, *Foundations of Modern Political Thought* (Vol. I–II).
 - Duffy, *The Stripping of the Altars*.
-

VI. Scientific Revolution & Enlightenment (Weeks 13–18)

Primary

- Bacon, *Novum Organum* aph. 1–70.
- Galileo, *Letter to Christina*.
- Descartes, *Discourse* I–IV; *Meditations* III–V.
- Pascal, *Pensées* §§72–277.
- Hobbes, *Leviathan* XIII–XVIII.
- Spinoza, *Ethics* I–II.
- Leibniz, *Monadology* §§1–90.
- Locke, *Second Treatise* §§1–51.
- Newton, *Principia* Bk I (Defs & Laws).
- Vico, *New Science* §§1–138.
- Hume, *Enquiry* §§2–5.
- Rousseau, *Social Contract* I.1–8.
- Voltaire, *Candide* (complete).
- **Kant, *Groundwork* — Preface & §I.**
- **Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason* — B-Preface; Introduction; Transcendental Aesthetic (A19–B73).**

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Age of Reason Begins; Age of Louis XIV; Age of Voltaire; Rousseau and Revolution*.
 - Koyré, *From the Closed World to the Infinite Universe*.
 - Butterfield, *Origins of Modern Science*. [NEW]
 - Westfall, *Construction of Modern Science*. [NEW]
 - Peter Gay, *The Enlightenment*.
 - Cassirer, *Kant's Life and Thought; Philosophy of the Enlightenment*.
 - Outram, *The Enlightenment*.
 - **(Optional) Diderot & d'Alembert, *Encyclopédie* (Preface; entries “Reason,” “Philosopher”). [NEW]**
 - **(Optional) Montesquieu, *Spirit of the Laws* Bk XI (separation of powers). [NEW]**
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VII. Revolution, Romanticism & Idealism (Weeks 19–23)

Primary

- Hegel, *Phenomenology* — Preface; “Self-Consciousness” (Lordship/Bondage).
- Hegel, *Philosophy of Right* — Preface; §§1–33, 142–157.
- Goethe, *Faust I*.
- Wordsworth & Coleridge, *Lyrical Ballads* (core poems).
- Blake, *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*.
- Engels, *Condition of the Working Class* chs. 1–3.
- Marx, *Economic & Philosophic Manuscripts* (Alienated Labor).
- Mill, *On Liberty* chs. 1–3.
- Nietzsche, *Genealogy of Morals* I–II.
- Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling* (Problema I).

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Age of Napoleon*.
- Berlin, *Roots of Romanticism*.
- Taylor, *Hegel and Modern Society*.
- Barzun, *From Dawn to Decadence*.
- Thompson, *Making of the English Working Class*.

VIII. Modernity, Realism & Pessimism (Weeks 24–27)

Primary

- Tocqueville, *Democracy in America* I.3–5.
- Whitman, *Leaves of Grass* (core poems).
- Schopenhauer, *World as Will and Representation* II §§18–22; *On the Suffering of the World*.
- Feuerbach, *Essence of Christianity* (Intro).
- William James, *Pragmatism* Lectures I–II.
- Dewey, *Experience and Nature* (sel.).
- Freud, *Interpretation of Dreams* ch. II.
- Freud, Sigmund. *Introductory Lectures on Psycho-Analysis*. 1916–17.
- Freud, Sigmund. *Civilization and Its Discontents*. 1930.
- Freud, Sigmund. *The Interpretation of Dreams*. 1900.

- Bergson, *Creative Evolution* (Intro).
- Conrad, *Heart of Darkness*.
- Flaubert, *Madame Bovary*; Tolstoy, *Anna Karenina* (sel. for seminar focus).

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Age of Napoleon* (Industrialism; Arts).
- Bryan Magee, *Philosophy of Schopenhauer*.
- Raymond Williams, *Culture and Society*.
- Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis*.
- Richard Holmes, *Age of Wonder*.



IX. 20th Century → Postwar (Weeks 28–40)

Primary

- Husserl, *Ideas I* §§27–49.
- Russell, *Problems of Philosophy* chs. 1–5.
- Heidegger, *Being and Time* §§1–6.
- Arendt, *Origins of Totalitarianism* Part III.
- Kafka, *Metamorphosis*.
- Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*.
- Beauvoir, *Ethics of Ambiguity* (sel.); *Second Sex* (sel.).
- Camus, *The Plague*.
- Gadamer, *Truth and Method* (Intro).
- Beckett, *Waiting for Godot*; Krapp's Last Tape.
- Borges, *Ficciones*.
- Spengler, *Decline of the West* Vol. I: Intro + "Meaning of Numbers".
- Adorno & Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment* ("Culture Industry").
- Derrida, *Of Grammatology* Preface & ch. 2.
- **Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition* chs. 1–2, Conclusion.**
- **Deleuze & Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus* "Introduction: Rhizome," Plateaus 1 & 3.**
- Lyotard, *The Postmodern Condition* §§1–6.
- Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation* (Preface; "Ecstasy of Communication").
- Pynchon, *The Crying of Lot 49*.

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Lessons of History*.
 - Löwith, *Meaning in History*.
 - Arendt, *Between Past and Future*.
 - George Steiner, *Heidegger*.
 - Claire Colebrook, *Understanding Deleuze*.
 - Manuel DeLanda, *Intensive Science and Virtual Philosophy*.
 - Peter Gay, *Modernism*.
 - Spengler, *Man and Technics*.
 - Adorno, *Aesthetic Theory*.
 - (Optional) Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* §§1–64. [NEW]
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X. Contemporary & Global Thought (Weeks 41–52)

Primary

- Fanon, *Wretched of the Earth* I–II.
- Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*.
- Achebe, *Things Fall Apart*.
- Marcuse, *One-Dimensional Man*.
- Butler, *Gender Trouble* (Intro; ch. 1).
- Saussure, *Course in General Linguistics* Pt I (for Week 35 bridge).
- Lévi-Strauss, *The Savage Mind* chs. 1–2 (bridge).
- MacIntyre, *After Virtue* chs. 1–3.
- Rorty, *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* Pt I.
- Haraway, “A Cyborg Manifesto”.
- Agamben, *Homo Sacer* I–II.
- Latour, *We Have Never Been Modern; Facing Gaia* ch. 2.
- Jonas, *Imperative of Responsibility* chs. 1–2.
- Morton, *Hyperobjects* chs. 1–3.
- Appiah, *Cosmopolitanism*.
- Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting* (Intro).
- Foucault, *Birth of Biopolitics* Lectures 1–3.
- Taylor, *A Secular Age* (Intro).

- Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (Intro).
- Appadurai, *Modernity at Large* chs. 1–3.
- Bhabha, *Location of Culture* ch. 1.
- Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century* (Intro).
- Rawls, *A Theory of Justice* §§1–4.
- Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind* ch. 3; Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?”.
- Robinson, *The Ministry for the Future*; Hamid, *Exit West*; Le Guin, *The Dispossessed*.
- **(Optional) Vatican II: *Gaudium et Spes* §§1–10. [NEW]**

Secondary / Historical

- Durant, *Lessons of History* (complete).
- Arendt, *The Human Condition*.
- Latour, *We Have Never Been Modern*; *Facing Gaia*.
- Taylor, *A Secular Age*.
- Bauman, *Liquid Modernity*; Beck, *Risk Society*.
- Sloterdijk, *Rage and Time*; Žižek, *Violence*.
- Mbembe, *Critique of Black Reason*.
- Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble*.
- Jonas, *Imperative of Responsibility*.
- Morton, *Hyperobjects*.
- Zuboff, *Surveillance Capitalism*.
- Bostrom, *Superintelligence*; Harari, *Homo Deus*.

Perfect — adding **essay/reflection prompts** for each week will make this curriculum truly pedagogically complete.

These can serve as **weekly essays (2–4 pages)** or **seminar discussion prompts** depending on how you use the plan.

Here’s **Weeks 1–10** (matching the five-column table you approved).

Each week has **2–3 essay or reflection topics** that blend historical, philosophical, and literary analysis.



Western Civilization, Philosophy & Literature — Essay / Reflection Topics

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
1	Origins of Civilization & Cosmic Order	1. Compare the conception of divine justice in <i>Hammurabi's Code</i> and <i>Genesis</i> —what does “law” mean in each? 2. How does <i>Gilgamesh</i> reflect the early human struggle against mortality and chaos? 3. In what sense can Hesiod’s <i>Theogony</i> be read as both myth and proto-philosophy?
2	Early Greece: Epic & Civic Beginnings	1. How does the heroism of Homer’s epics differ from the moral order of <i>Works and Days</i> ? 2. In what ways do the early Presocratics transform mythic explanations into rational inquiry? 3. What vision of the “good life” emerges from Solon’s poetry compared to Hesiod’s?
3	Tragedy, War & the Polis	1. How do Aeschylus and Sophocles dramatize the tension between divine and civic law? 2. What does the Funeral Oration reveal about the Athenian concept of freedom and virtue? 3. How does tragedy act as political education for the polis?
4	Philosophy & the Examined Life	1. Is Socrates’ defense in the <i>Apology</i> a rejection of democratic Athens or its fulfillment? 2. How does Plato’s <i>Republic</i> redefine justice compared to Thucydides’ realism? 3. Contrast Aristophanes’ satire in <i>Clouds</i> with Plato’s philosophical Socrates—who understands Athens better?
5	Aristotle & Greek Science	1. What does Aristotle mean by “form” and “final cause,” and how do they differ from modern scientific explanation? 2. How does Aristotle’s notion of <i>eudaimonia</i> reconcile ethics and teleology? 3. In what sense is Greek science a moral pursuit?
6	Civic Virtue & Exemplarity	1. How do Plutarch’s Lives construct a moral model for political leadership? 2. Compare Cicero’s <i>On Duties</i> with Aristotle’s <i>Ethics</i> —what continuity or rupture exists between Greek and Roman virtue? 3. Is republican virtue compatible with empire?
7	Hellenistic Philosophy & Empire	1. Compare Stoic resignation with Epicurean moderation—are they responses to political powerlessness? 2. How do Seneca or Epictetus preserve freedom within empire? 3. To what extent is Gibbon right that philosophy replaced civic virtue in Rome?
8	Rome, Law & Christianity	1. How does Virgil’s <i>Aeneid</i> balance fate and freedom in the founding of empire? 2. In what ways does Augustine’s <i>Confessions</i> reinterpret Roman virtue through grace? 3. How does Gibbon’s narrative of Christian “progress” invert Augustine’s <i>City of God</i> ?
9	Early Middle Ages	1. How did Benedict’s monastic rule preserve classical rationality in a religious form? 2. Compare Boethius’ <i>Consolation</i> and Anselm’s <i>Proslogion</i> : is faith compatible with philosophy? 3. What does Gibbon’s view of decline reveal about Enlightenment historiography?
10	Scholasticism & Mysticism	1. How does Aquinas reconcile Aristotle’s reason with Christian revelation? 2. How does Dante’s <i>Inferno</i> embody the synthesis of medieval cosmology and ethics? 3. In what sense is mysticism (e.g. Julian of Norwich) a critique of scholasticism?

Excellent — here is **Weeks 11–20** with focused, essay-level prompts designed to provoke historical, philosophical, and literary synthesis.

These are suitable for 3–5 page analytical essays, reflective journals, or seminar papers.
Each week continues the sequence seamlessly from your curriculum.



Western Civilization, Philosophy & Literature — Essay / Reflection Topics (Weeks 11–20)

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
11	Renaissance Humanism	1. How does Pico's <i>Oration on the Dignity of Man</i> redefine the medieval hierarchy of being? 2. In what ways does Machiavelli's <i>Prince</i> secularize classical virtue? 3. Compare Hamlet's interior conflict to the humanist tension between reason and will.
12	Reformation & Skepticism	1. How does Luther's concept of faith transform the relationship between conscience and authority? 2. How does Montaigne's skepticism respond to the religious turmoil of the Reformation? 3. Compare Erasmus' <i>Praise of Folly</i> to Luther's theology—are they divergent or continuous critiques of corruption?
13	Science & Method	1. How does Bacon's inductive method reflect a moral as well as scientific reform? 2. Compare Galileo's <i>Letter to Christina</i> and Descartes' <i>Discourse</i> : do they share a theological concern or diverge completely? 3. In what ways does the Scientific Revolution inherit the metaphysical assumptions of scholasticism?
14	Political Order & Nature	1. How does Hobbes' vision of the state reinterpret classical virtue? 2. Compare Spinoza's rational ethics with Hobbes' mechanical politics—who is more modern? 3. Does Milton's <i>Paradise Lost</i> dramatize the birth of modern liberty or its fall?
15	Faith & Reason	1. How does Descartes attempt to reconcile faith and reason in the <i>Meditations</i> ? 2. Does Pascal's wager represent skepticism or piety? 3. How do Racine's tragedies embody the moral tension between passion and providence?
16	Natural Law & Enlightenment	1. How does Locke's <i>Second Treatise</i> transform the theological idea of natural law into a liberal principle? 2. Compare Newton's laws of motion with Vico's "new science" of history—two modes of order. 3. Does Pope's <i>Essay on Man</i> affirm or critique Enlightenment optimism?
17	Enlightenment & Critique	1. How does Hume's skepticism about causation challenge scientific certainty? 2. How does Rousseau's concept of freedom differ from Hobbes and Locke? 3. In Kant's <i>Critique of Pure Reason</i> , what limits does reason set on itself—and why is this a moral act?
18	Revolution & Rights	1. Compare Rousseau's and Jefferson's notions of political legitimacy. 2. How does the <i>Declaration of the Rights of Man</i> reinterpret natural law? 3. In Goethe's <i>Faust</i> , how does the pursuit of knowledge become a political problem?
19	Romanticism & the Self	1. How does Hegel's "lordship and bondage" dialectic reinterpret freedom? 2. Compare Wordsworth's and Blake's visions of nature—does Romanticism oppose or fulfill Enlightenment reason? 3. How does the Romantic imagination transform the problem of evil into a

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
20	Industrialism & Ethics	creative act? 1. In what ways does Hegel's <i>Philosophy of Right</i> diagnose the moral cost of industrial society? 2. How does Dickens' <i>Hard Times</i> reflect the collapse of the Enlightenment faith in progress? 3. Compare Marx's critique of alienation with the Christian idea of sin—are they structurally similar?

Perfect — here's the next set, **Weeks 21–30**, which covers the transition from **Victorian faith and doubt** through **existentialism, modernism, and early 20th-century crises**.

Each week again has 2–3 rich prompts that bridge history, philosophy, and literature.

Western Civilization, Philosophy & Literature — Essay / Reflection Topics (Weeks 21–30)

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
21	Faith, Science & Doubt	1. How does Darwin's <i>Origin of Species</i> redefine humanity's moral status in nature? 2. Compare Kierkegaard's "leap of faith" with Comte's "positive science." 3. Does Victorian doubt represent moral weakness or intellectual integrity?
22	Modern Self & Liberty	1. How does Mill's <i>On Liberty</i> reconcile individuality with social duty? 2. In what ways does Nietzsche's <i>Genealogy of Morals</i> expose the hidden violence of moral ideals? 3. How does Ibsen's <i>A Doll's House</i> dramatize freedom as both liberation and exile?
23	Pessimism & Realism	1. How does Schopenhauer's metaphysics of will anticipate Freud's unconscious? 2. Compare Tolstoy's and Flaubert's moral universes—what replaces divine meaning in realism? 3. Is aesthetic realism a form of resignation or rebellion?
24	Democracy, Pragmatism & Modernism I	1. How does Tocqueville's analysis of democracy illuminate the tension between equality and greatness? 2. In Whitman's poetry, how does democracy become a spiritual experience? 3. Does pragmatism (James, Dewey) complete or dissolve the Enlightenment project?
25	Democracy, Pragmatism & Modernism II	1. How do Marx and Engels transform Hegelian dialectic into revolutionary theory? 2. How does Freud's <i>Interpretation of Dreams</i> turn the self into a scientific object? 3. Compare Bergson's "creative evolution" with Darwin's natural selection—what counts as freedom in each?
26	Modern Mind & Crisis	1. In Conrad's <i>Heart of Darkness</i> , what does "darkness" symbolize—colonial guilt, the unconscious, or civilization itself? 2. How does Auerbach's <i>Mimesis</i> interpret realism as a moral vision? 3. Can the modern novel succeed where religion failed?
27	The Great War & Disillusionment	1. How does Husserl's call to return "to the things themselves" answer the crisis of meaning after World War I? 2. Does Owen's poetry preserve or destroy the dignity of sacrifice? 3. How does

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
28	Totalitarianism & Alienation	scientific progress (Kuhn's revolutions) mirror political collapse? 1. How does Heidegger's <i>Being and Time</i> rethink alienation at the ontological level? 2. In what ways does Arendt's <i>Origins of Totalitarianism</i> link ideology to loneliness? 3. How does Kafka's <i>Metamorphosis</i> render metaphysics absurd?
29	Existentialism & the Absurd	1. Compare Sartre's and Camus's conceptions of freedom—does meaning depend on rebellion or acceptance? 2. In what sense is Beauvoir's <i>Ethics of Ambiguity</i> a feminist re-writing of existential ethics? 3. Does Orwell's <i>1984</i> express existential despair or political prophecy?
30	Renewal & Meaning	1. How does Gadamer's <i>Truth and Method</i> recover meaning from history and language? 2. What does Beckett's <i>Waiting for Godot</i> reveal about post-religious hope? 3. How does Arendt's <i>Between Past and Future</i> redefine freedom as thought rather than will?

Excellent — here's **Weeks 31–40**, moving through the **mid-20th century crisis of civilization**, **postwar philosophy**, and **post-structuralist transformations** (Spengler, Adorno, Deleuze, Derrida, Lyotard).

Each week balances a historical or philosophical theme with interpretive questions that encourage synthesis across texts.

Western Civilization, Philosophy & Literature — Essay / Reflection Topics (Weeks 31–40)

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
31	Civilizational Decline	1. How does Spengler's <i>Decline of the West</i> reinterpret history as organic fate rather than progress? 2. In what sense is Adorno & Horkheimer's <i>Dialectic of Enlightenment</i> a critique of reason's self-destruction? 3. Does Borges's <i>Ficciones</i> affirm or deny the possibility of truth in a decaying culture?
32	Decolonization & Global South	1. How do Fanon and Gandhi present liberation as both psychological and political? 2. What does <i>Things Fall Apart</i> reveal about the violence of "civilization"? 3. How do Durant's reflections on culture contrast with post-colonial accounts of history?
33	1960s Revolt & Freedom	1. How does Marcuse's <i>One-Dimensional Man</i> reinterpret Marx under late capitalism? 2. Is García Márquez's magical realism an aesthetic rebellion against materialism? 3. How do protest movements of the 1960s revive or abandon Enlightenment ideals?
34	Feminism & Identity	1. In what ways does Beauvoir's <i>Second Sex</i> expose the metaphysical foundations of patriarchy? 2. How does Butler's <i>Gender Trouble</i> transform existential freedom into performativity? 3. Can Morrison's <i>Beloved</i> be read as theology of memory?
35	Structuralism &	1. How do Saussure and Lévi-Strauss redefine "truth" as structure? 2.

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
	Myth	Does Calvino's <i>If on a Winter's Night a Traveler</i> parody or fulfill the structuralist dream of total narrative? 3. Compare mythic explanation in <i>The Theogony</i> (Week 1) with Lévi-Strauss's anthropological method—what has changed?
36	Post-Structuralism & Difference	1. How does Derrida's <i>Of Grammatology</i> challenge the Enlightenment idea of presence? 2. In Deleuze's <i>Difference and Repetition</i> , what replaces identity as the basis of thought? 3. Are Lyotard's "language games" the end or the continuation of modern reason?
37	Ethics & Community	1. How does MacIntyre's <i>After Virtue</i> attempt to recover moral tradition after relativism? 2. In what sense is Rorty's <i>Mirror of Nature</i> a pragmatic ethics rather than a skepticism? 3. How do Beckett's late plays turn ethical reflection into form?
38	Neoliberalism & Media	1. How does Baudrillard's theory of simulation redefine ideology? 2. What does Rushdie's <i>Midnight's Children</i> suggest about narrative and national identity? 3. Does postmodern media represent freedom or new control?
39	Posthumanism & Biopolitics	1. Compare Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" with Agamben's <i>Homo Sacer</i> : how do both redefine what counts as "human"? 2. How does <i>Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?</i> dramatize ethical ambiguity in technology? 3. Is Spengler's technological pessimism vindicated or overturned by posthumanism?
40	Ecology & the Anthropocene	1. How do Jonas's <i>Imperative of Responsibility</i> and Morton's <i>Hyperobjects</i> recast ethics for the planetary era? 2. Does Latour's <i>Facing Gaia</i> offer a new theology of nature? 3. How does Ghosh's <i>Great Derangement</i> connect climate crisis to failures of imagination?

Perfect — this final sequence, **Weeks 41–52**, concludes the curriculum with **global modernity, technology, secularism, and the post-human horizon**.

Each week's questions are crafted to invite synthesis with earlier material — from Hammurabi to Harari — so the student ends the year with a panoramic grasp of Western (and now global) civilization's arc.

Western Civilization, Philosophy & Literature — Essay / Reflection Topics (Weeks 41–52)

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
41	Globalization & Pluralism	1. How does Appiah's <i>Cosmopolitanism</i> reconcile cultural diversity with universal ethics? 2. In what ways does Coetzee's <i>Elizabeth Costello</i> test the limits of moral sympathy across species and cultures? 3. Does the cosmopolitan ideal renew or dissolve the classical idea of virtue?
42	Memory & Trauma	1. How does Ricoeur's <i>Memory, History, Forgetting</i> redefine truth

Week	Theme	Essay / Reflection Topics
		after historical catastrophe? 2. In Sebald's <i>Austerlitz</i> , can narrative redeem trauma or only repeat it? 3. Compare medieval confession (Week 8) with modern testimony—what has replaced salvation?
43	Digital Culture & Knowledge	1. Does the digital age fulfill Bacon's dream of universal knowledge or parody it? 2. How does Wallace's <i>Infinite Jest</i> depict information as both liberation and imprisonment? 3. Is the Internet a new polis or a new Tower of Babel?
44	Populism & Crisis of Democracy	1. How do Sloterdijk's <i>Rage and Time</i> and Žižek's <i>Violence</i> interpret resentment as a political force? 2. Does Atwood's <i>Handmaid's Tale</i> echo the prophetic voices of Augustine and Dante? 3. What happens to truth when democracy loses shared myth?
45	Global Modernities	1. How does Mbembe's <i>Critique of Black Reason</i> provincialize the Enlightenment ideal of rational man? 2. In what sense is Adichie's <i>Half of a Yellow Sun</i> a counter-narrative to Western universal history? 3. Can post-colonial humanism avoid repeating Western humanism?
46	Economics & Inequality	1. Compare Marx's <i>Capital</i> and Piketty's <i>Capital in the 21st Century</i> : what endures of the critique of accumulation? 2. How does Rawls's <i>Theory of Justice</i> secularize natural-law ethics? 3. Is economic inequality a moral or metaphysical problem?
47	Science & Consciousness	1. How do Chalmers and Nagel reopen the question of the soul in secular language? 2. Does materialism explain or erase consciousness? 3. Compare Aristotle's <i>De Anima</i> (Week 5) and modern philosophy of mind: what has been lost in translation?
48	Technology & Surveillance	1. How does Foucault's <i>Birth of Biopolitics</i> anticipate Zuboff's <i>Surveillance Capitalism</i> ? 2. In what sense is Gibson's <i>Neuromancer</i> a morality play about information and control? 3. Can freedom survive when the gaze becomes digital?
49	Religion & Secularism	1. How does Taylor's <i>Secular Age</i> reinterpret disenchantment as spiritual opportunity? 2. In Eliot's <i>Four Quartets</i> , does poetry restore transcendence or mourn its loss? 3. Compare Vatican II's <i>Gaudium et Spes</i> with Augustine's <i>City of God</i> : continuity or rupture?
50	Ecology & Hope	1. Does Latour's <i>Facing Gaia</i> offer a new covenant between science and faith? 2. How does Robinson's <i>Ministry for the Future</i> translate Jonas's ethics into political fiction? 3. Is ecological thought the true heir of the Enlightenment or its negation?
51	Migration & Identity	1. How do Appadurai's <i>Modernity at Large</i> and Bhabha's <i>Location of Culture</i> redefine belonging? 2. In Hamid's <i>Exit West</i> , what replaces the classical journey of the hero? 3. How does mobility reshape memory, community, and moral responsibility?
52	Future of the Human	1. In Bostrom's <i>Superintelligence</i> and Harari's <i>Homo Deus</i> , does reason transcend or annihilate humanity? 2. How does Le Guin's <i>Dispossessed</i> re-imagine utopia after modernity's collapse? 3. Looking back from Week 1, has Western civilization advanced, declined, or transformed in kind?